UNDERSTANDING **STRESS**

The perception of threat sets off a series of physiological reactions along the HPA or hypothalamus-pituitary-adrenal axis that determine the body's fight or flight response

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS** & **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**
Text by **SONALI ACHARJEE**

74%

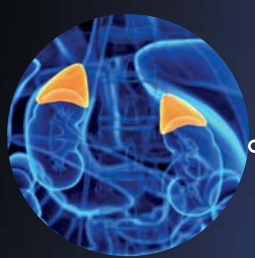
of the 10,000 Indians surveyed by The Centre of Healing in Dec. 2020 reported stress; 88% anxiety

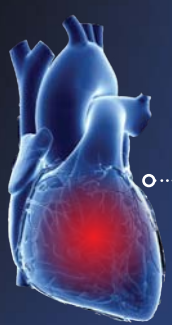
91%

of 1,100 Indian professionals in a 2021 Oracle study said they were stressed, compared to 80% globally

How we respond







1 Threat
Perception begins in the brain

2 Hypothalamus
The command centre of the brain, it sends the corticotropin-releasing hormone to activate the pituitary gland below

3 Pituitary gland
The control room of the endocrine system, it secretes the adrenocorticotropic hormone to alert the adrenal glands

4 Adrenal glands
Triangular-shaped organs located above our kidneys, they release the stress hormone called cortisol

5 Cortisol
An anti-inflammatory steroid, it provides the body some extra boost, and activates its sympathetic nervous system

6 Sympathetic Nervous System
It causes the heart to race, BP to shoot up, and breath to become fast, providing the body an energy boost

7 Inflammation
Once the threat recedes, cortisol should reduce. But chronic stress leads to overproduction, which causes inflammation and damage to vital organs